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THE HINDU



A 23-year-old reading revolution is afoot at Vyasarpadi through a community library **P3**

WHAT IS SHAKTHISREE'S 'OLD FRIEND' ABOUT? **P4**



The final battle

One last stand
Vijay in a still from *Jana Nayagan*; (inset) H Vinoth.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND THAMODHARAN B

what comes well to him and how to present those strengths.” One would assume a star stepping into the political arena would try and tailor Vinoth’s film to boost his political career, but the filmmaker assures there was no interference. “In fact, even when we included some meta-political elements, he advised us to avoid them and ensure that it stays true to my school of filmmaking. Moreover, Vijay sir could have gotten any director to direct his final film, so he didn’t need to interfere and push me to do something.” The retirement of ‘actor’ Vijay from films will be a huge loss to the film industry, says the director who has also helmed three films with Ajith. “Someone pointed out how Vijay sir contributes to approximately 25% of the revenue generated in a year in Tamil cinema. As a director, I think, directors will miss the high salaries they would usually get for his films. As a storyteller, with a Vijay film, your content will reach even a child and play a stronger role in the lives of people. Tamil cinema will miss him,” he signs off.

Jana Nayagan releases in theatres today.

Filmmaker H Vinoth speaks about helming ‘Thalapathy’ Vijay’s swansong film *Jana Nayagan* and the former actor’s support during testing times

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For a moment, step into the shoes of filmmaker H Vinoth. You get the opportunity to direct ‘Thalapathy’ Vijay, in a politically-laden film that will mark his transformation from actor to politician. You make the film with the backing of KVN Productions, and just as you eagerly await its release during Pongal, it snowballs into a controversy. The delay in the censor certification indefinitely pushes the film’s release, and the subsequent legal battle makes one wonder if it will ever release at all. And, as if this isn’t enough to test your resolve, the film leaks online even before it arrives in theatres. On one hand, Vijay takes oath as the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, and on the other, your labour of love is being illegally watched by millions.

That *Jana Nayagan* finally hits screens today should have been joyous for Vinoth; except, it is not. “I have mixed feelings. On one hand, I am happy that we have received the censor certificate, but also sad that we got an A-certificate. I am happy that the film is releasing, but I am also waiting to see if audiences will come to theatres to watch a film that was leaked. The bookings are strong, so I am hoping that people will support the film,” says Vinoth in a chat ahead of the film’s release. If there was a silver lining to the controversy surrounding *Jana Nayagan*, it was the show of support the film got from across the Indian film industry. “Many industry colleagues reached out to me. I also understand that a few others might have hesitated, fearing political pressure. But I thank all of them, including those who kept me in their thoughts,” says Vinoth.

However, when asked what emboldened him to brace through the storm, the filmmaker is quick to credit Vijay and the film’s producer Venkat K Narayana. If it were any other producer, Vinoth says, they would have taken it to the media and the Producers Council. “And if it were any other actor, they might have distanced themselves from the issue.

But both my star and my producer stood united to face any problem that might arise. And that gave us a lot of hope. Secondly, I wanted that core message in the film to reach the people.”

Whether the ‘message’ reaches the audiences is what Vinoth now cares about – that’s all the filmmaker can look forward to as success for a film that has leaked online, he believes. “I care about whether the film impacts the lives of its audiences and brings about some change to their reality. If audiences from different religious, caste, linguistic and regional backgrounds come out of the film and vow to stay united, then that would be the victory of *Jana Nayagan*,” says Vinoth.

Jana Nayagan is the remake of the hit 2023 Telugu actioner *Bhagavanth Kesari*. Interestingly, it was Vijay who prompted Vinoth to watch the Nandamuri Balakrishna-starrer to see if it could be remade. While the original dealt with a larger-than-life character’s relationship with his daughter, the remake extends upon the original to explore psychological

Any other actor might have distanced themselves from the controversy surrounding Jana Nayagan. But ‘Thalapathy’ Vijay stood by my side

H VINOTH
Filmmaker



The story so far

- *Jana Nayagan* was originally slated for a festival release on January 9, ahead of Pongal.
- This could not be met due to the delay in the censor certificate and the subsequent legal battle, which snowballed into a major controversy.
- On April 10, fans of Vijay were in for a shock as a HD print of *Jana Nayagan* was leaked on piracy sites.

and political fear. “We had to add something special to the material because, today if audiences know it’s a remake, they will immediately watch the original. So we had to expand that core conflict.” And because the hero is a politician in real life, Vinoth had to make the father-and-daughter story into that of a leader. “Now, that leader needs to address an issue, and so we looked at what’s plaguing India in contemporary times.”

While making *Jana Nayagan*, Vinoth was struck by Vijay’s work ethic, which he believes helped build the star’s on-screen aura. “He must have put in tremendous hard work to create a world for himself. I observed how he approaches what seems like an ordinary dialogue. After we finished a shot, he wouldn’t simply stay on set and chat with people; he would start preparing for the next shot, and he would converse with relevant technicians about it.” The director even says that if Vijay had worked a certain number of hours each day in his career, he must have worked every second of those hours. “I admired how aware he was of

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The cover story

As Art of the Book opens at DakshinaChitra, Sunandini Banerjee talks about designing Seagull Books' iconic covers, reading through images, and the future of independent publishing

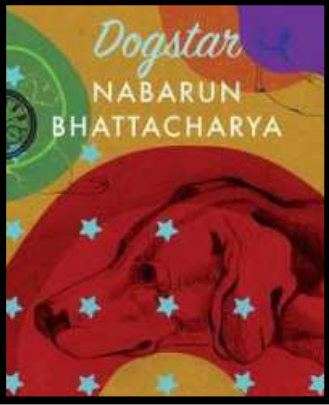
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There is a saying – ‘don't judge a book by its cover’. But when the covers are elaborate stories in themselves, one can no longer separate them from the narrative within. When Sunandini Banerjee, senior editor and graphic designer, Seagull Books, designs a cover, it becomes more than an image wrapping a book. Through collage, abstraction, and illustration, her covers transform books by authors from different cultures and continents into symbolic visual narratives that often stay with a reader as much as the words within them.



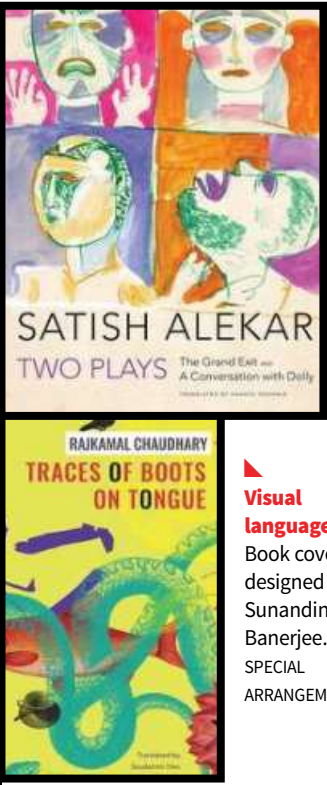
of the Book, at DakshinaChitra, one can see some iconic book covers designed and curated by Sunandini, where the covers become a dialogue between image and the text. Founded by Naveen Kishore in 1982, Seagull Books is an independent publishing house that has built a catalogue that spans continents and disciplines. The exhibition traces that journey through covers for books by writers including Mahasweta Devi, Romila Thapar, Christoph Ransmayr, László Krasznahorkai, Satish Alekar, Nabarun Bhattacharya and Dominique Noguez, offering a glimpse into nearly four decades of independent publishing.

Sunandini's own journey at Seagull began not as a designer, but as an editor. Despite, growing up in a family that loved books, she never imagined a career in design. “I couldn't draw,” she says. “In those days there was really no question of going to art school.



Either you could draw or you couldn't. It just remained an interest – I never imagined I could actually do it.” It was only after she joined Seagull Books in 2000, as publishing was transitioning into the digital era, that a new possibility emerged.

“The computer became a magic box. Suddenly I could work with images in ways I couldn't in the real world. Seagull never told me,



Visual language
Book covers designed by Sunandini Banerjee. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

“That's not your job.’ I kept asking, “Can I try this?” Maybe a poster. Then some pages of the *Seagull Theatre Quarterly*. Then eventually a book cover. I was allowed to fail and to try again. That's how in time I became a designer,” she says.

Sunandini's design process begins long before she opens her computer screen. “First comes the text,” she explains. “I'll read the title, and immediately some visual element leaps into my mind. Then I read the jacket and often the book itself. Even if it's fiction, I need to know the time, place, atmosphere, the age of the character – because the character may be imaginary but the place is not.”

As she reads, she begins collecting the visual elements. “I pull keywords out of the texts, like the place, time, city, maybe the important flower, or the ocean. Then I use the Internet to search for those elements. You don't always know what a finished cover looks like. You're looking for bits and pieces, and then placing them and seeing what works together.”



For Sunandini, every cover has to emerge from the story itself rather than from a pre-conceived notion of a place or culture. “I am against exoticisation,” she says. “I don't want to put a peacock on the book cover just to tell it's a story from India.” The research cannot be short-circuited.

That sentiment is reflected in the covers, be it DR Nagaraj's *The Flaming Feet and Other Essays*, Romila Thapar's *Past as Present*, or Nabarun Bhattacharya's *Herbert*. The covers are surreal, edgy, and contemporary, where different elements are not just placed with one another, but complement each other in their own way.

In an age dominated by online shopping and endless scrolling, Sunandini believes that thoughtful designs matter more than ever. “We're bombarded by images all the time. To break through that visual noise and arrest someone's attention even for a few seconds requires greater care. You can't say this book should look like five other books. There's even more pressure to be unique now,” she says.

Despite independent publishing houses facing challenges today, Sunandini remains hugely optimistic. “The smaller houses are the ones that are driving the change, in terms of the content, because they have more independence.”

With the Art of the Book, Sunandini hopes that the audience leaves curious enough to seek out the stories behind the covers. “If someone among them is inspired enough to become a cover designer, or a translator, why not? I hope they leave a little bit happier,” says Sunandini.

Art of the Book is on at Varjia Art Gallery, DakshinaChitra Museum till September 6, all days except Tuesdays, from 10am to 6pm (till 7pm on weekends). Entry is ₹200.

Keeping the beat going

Jus Drums' students belted out Tamil cinema hits on its annual day

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As the spotlight fell on the Mylapore Fine Arts Club stage on July 18, performers were seen carrying paint buckets, empty cartons, metal pipes, washing machine tubes, water cans and a car wheel, leaving the audience intrigued. Moments later, these everyday objects transformed into percussion instruments.

“The piece was inspired by three of the five elements of Nature – Earth, Water and Air,” said S Muralikrishnan, also known as Drums Murali, the curator of the show and the founder of Jus Drums.

Murali has been teaching how to play drums since 1999. He founded Jus Drums in 2003. Since then, around 2,500 students have trained under him. From Ilaiyaraaja's ‘En Jodi Manja Kurivi’ to AR Rahman's ‘Yaakkai Thiri’, the students of this institute celebrating its 24th annual day, performed a series of 11 pieces. As a tribute to late singer S Janaki who died on July 11, students also played the song ‘Etho Mogam’ from the film *Kozhi Koovuthu* too – a moving tribute.

Murali has been teaching students aged between six and 75. Over the years, Murali has shared the stage with several musical legends including KJ Yesudas, AR Rahman, Usha Uthup and Shankar Mahadevan.

“What the students showcased today is not just a result of their passion for music, but also their discipline,” said Poornima Narasimhan, a performer's mother. Murali says that preparations for the annual concert took nearly a month, and adds that he would gladly do it all over again.



In sync At the Jus Drums annual day. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Empire on the rocks

Inspired by the storied dynasty, ITC Grand Chola introduces Chola-tails, a new cocktail selection

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The Cheroot Malt Bar at Chennai's ITC Grand Chola lives many lives. By day, it is a polished cigar lounge. Come the weekend, and the room sheds its restraint. The lights dim, the music grows louder and a younger crowd takes over, turning the space into an unlikely dance floor between walls that, on most evenings, play host to men in well-tailored suits.

It is perhaps fitting, then, that this is where ITC Grand Chola chose to unveil the latest edition of its signature cocktail programme, Cholatails, that draws from Tamil Nadu's culinary traditions, trade history and everyday food memories.

“The idea behind Cholatails was never to create ‘historical cocktails’. It was to create a contemporary beverage experience rooted in the spirit of the Chola dynasty and the culture of Tamil Nadu,” says Shaariq Akhtar, general manager, ITC Grand Chola.

The new menu according to Shaariq, was built around three guiding ideas. The first, looked at ingredients with historical significance during the Chola period, including jasmine, turmeric, vetiver, jaggery, betel leaf, avarampoo and more. The second, focussed on flavours that are rooted in Tamil Nadu, like rose water (*panneer*), black rice (*karupu kavuni arisi*), *nannari*, moringa and other botanicals. The third was ensuring that every drink first worked as a well-balanced cocktail. With five cocktails (starting at ₹1,300) and one zero

proof drink, the new Cholatails experience begins with Pachai, a vodka, green apple fizz with notes of moringa, which is grown on the campus of the hotel. It is a tart, fresh drink to begin with. The Sunshine, which is a tequila-based cocktail with turmeric, lime, and passion fruit has a whiff of camphor. The turmeric taste lingers and reminds one of temples.

Usually the combination of rice and pickle is not something you expect in a glass, but the cocktail with the same name does just that. “This uses *karupu kavuni arisi*, which is infused in the tequila. That same rice is taken out to make a hydrosol (a water-based by product of plant distillation) to add flavour. Then that leftover boiled rice is mixed with pickle to make it into a papad and served with the drink,” says Ajit Balgi, founder of Happy High, a Mumbai-based beverage education and consultancy firm.

We also sample Doctor's Pride, the whiskey and avarampoo milk-washed cocktail. It is floral and smokey, and makes you want to go back for more. The finale comes in the shape of The Hedonist. True to its name, it is heady with whiskey, bitters, orange, jasmine and smoked cherry, and best suited for a night-cap.

It is evident that Cholatails looks inwards, finding enough inspiration in Tamil Nadu's own history, landscapes and pantry to fill a glass.

Cholatails draws from Tamil Nadu's culinary traditions, trade history and everyday food memories



Click your glass
Rice and Pickle part of Cheroot's menu. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Going the Korean way (Clockwise from right) Kimchi fried rice; mascarpone toast; and the interiors of Ba Da Bom in Nungambakkam. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



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The innocuous spiral staircase tucked behind Kup Coffee Roasters in Nungambakkam now leads to ‘Chicken Shop’ neon signs, cans of flavoured Milkis, and Ba Da Bom.

We enter to pop music blaring from the speakers, a busy open kitchen, and a cooler stocked with some K-Drama-famous cream sodas, Maxim coffee, and tiny bottles of Bacchus energy drinks.

Jivesh Goenka, who calls Ba Da Bom a ‘Korean table’, launched Kup nearly three years ago. He speaks of his love for Asian food, visiting hawker stalls in Singapore and Vietnam, and how that influenced his decision to this new space. “On a trip to Pune, I spotted Ba Da Bom and walked in. A meal of mascarpone toast and soju later, I knew I had to bring this to Chennai,” he recalls.

Currently open for dinners alone, Jivesh says their reservations are being steadily booked out, and plans to open for lunch and takeaways, as well as introducing an exciting beverage menu are in the offing.

While Ba Da Bom functions as a bar and restaurant in Pune, the Chennai outpost, Jivesh says, captures his favourite part of dining at vibrant East-Asian street-side eateries; right from the commotion in the kitchen, the delicious smell of food being cooked, and the cooler laden with

Hey Seoul sister

Hidden above Kup Coffee Roasters, Ba Da Bom brings together Korean comfort food, retro arcade games, K-drama favourites

drinks. “I wanted to give Chennai something fun, whacky and different, a space with no inhibitions. The focus was also on keeping the Korean food flavourful, and acceptable to the Indian palate,” he says.

We begin with the Shake Shake Kimchi Salad, a starter that requires our participation. A bag is handed to us, into which go crisp napa cabbage, cucumbers, spring onions and carrots, followed by a sweet-and-savoury kimchi dressing. The crunchy salad that emerges after a good shake is a refreshing start to our meal.

We then dig into gochujang black pepper beef, which has bits of meat coated in a wok-pepper glaze, scallions and sesame. The sweet hit from the gochujang, the pepper punch and perfectly cooked meat makes this starter a winner. A Korean table calls for fried chicken or bbq, and we pick the latter. The Belgian pork belly and spring onion barbecue, though coated in a delectably sticky glaze, could have been more tender. The mascarpone toast, which started it all, comes



highly recommended and we see why. There is soft, fried brioche bread to bite into, topped with a cloud of mascarpone, yuzu and chilli oil.

Hallyu much?
Ba Da Bom's menu is extensive in its categories; there are sandwiches (Korean-style, much like the Eggdrop ones you are sure to have seen in a K-Drama), fried chicken, noodles, rice and ramen, and yet it all does not feel overwhelming. The choices are simple enough, and the focus is on keeping the menu fuss-free and accessible, Jivesh says.

The noodle selection includes ramen, japchae and cold noodles and while cold soba noodles feel



like an appropriate choice given Chennai's never-ending summer, a yearning for a comfort dish takes us to the rice side of things. The Koreans thankfully love their rice as much as we do, and cast-iron kimchi rice fits the bill. The sticky rice is on the mushier side, and we mix in an over-easy egg, kimchi, scallions and crisp bacon bits. The rice is comforting, though we would not mind an added hit of heat.

We have been helping ourselves to drinks from the cooler all night; cans of flavoured Milkis (Korea's famous cream soda), Chillsung cider, and Maxim coffee lattes. There is also a snacks counter right next to the open kitchen with chips, cookies and ramen from Korean brands to pick up while leaving. An arcade gaming machine on the side has the younger diners jostling around. With the loud music, and the clatter of plates from the kitchen, this is not a space to head to for a quiet dinner, but the experience comes together exactly how Jivesh initially describes it: a whacky, fun space that does not hold back.

All of this, says Vidhya Vijay, brand head, are conscious design choices. “We wanted to recreate a typical food street from South Korea; right from the dusty, winding spiral staircase that seems to lead nowhere, neon light boxes, the wires hanging and the loud music you are welcomed with,” she says. “We wanted to have an abundance of everything; noise, colour and character. And the aim was not to front a single dish or a product, but fun,” she says.

For everyone even remotely Hallyu-obsessed, check out the pinboard which has posters (spot BTS or one from the K-Drama *Twinkling Watermelon* there). And to end the night, pick a slip predicting one's fortune from the cheery yellow machine by the door. The post-meal high feels like a good time to receive predictions, whether ominous or joyful.

Mine thankfully says, “The future owes you three pleasant surprises.”

Ba Da Bom is located above Kup, Nungambakkam, and costs ₹2,000 for a meal for two. Follow badabom.chennai on Instagram for reservations



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For 23 years, a small corner of Chennai's Vyasarpadi has been transforming into a makeshift library once a week. This week, it is Satyamoorthy Nagar Park's turn.

With books tucked inside transparent pouches tied to tree branches and magazine racks overflowing with journals, readers huddle together for another session of reading. Among them is 43-year-old B Meenakshi, trying hard to recollect the title of her favourite story. *Ali Baba and the Forty Thieves*, she finally says, her face lighting up as she remembers it. Being a school dropout and a domestic worker in Vyasarpadi, Meenakshi did not have many opportunities to pick up a book. Today, she has read 27 titles. All of this is thanks to Aarvam, an NGO that has been striving to create change in the community through a reading revolution. What started initially as a mobile library with books loaded in a van has transformed into a community library and reading circle.

Revolution by the book

Reading as recreation is the focus of Aarvam, a 23-year-old community library in Vyasarpadi

"I started reading during the time of the COVID-19 pandemic. Back then, I enjoyed watching television serials and wasn't interested in books. Then, children from Aarvam's tuition centre brought me a few books and persuaded me to give reading a try, to which I finally agreed," said Meenakshi, recalling her journey with books.

Vyasarpadi has a significant population of residents from economically disadvantaged backgrounds, including families who have migrated from different villages and those who have been resettled in the area. The attempt is to allow for reading to exist as a

recreational activity here. The group meets once a week and their collection includes books written by Tamil authors and translated works from around the world. As the reading circle settles down in silence, 85-year-old Muthuswamy starts browsing through the magazine rack.

Aarvam began in 1984 after S Shanmugam, a resident, wanted reading to be accessible to the marginalised, particularly the neighbourhood's dropouts

Book talk Every week, volunteers of Aarvam set up book shelves stacked with titles for members. ELSA SUNNY

Expressing his strong preference, he says, "I only read literature and poetry. I won't read books related to politics or the government. Today I saw a book by Karl Marx titled *The Communist Manifesto*. I won't like it."

Commending the efforts of volunteers organising the reading circle, Muthuswamy adds that the organisation is doing something that many wealthy people would hesitate to do.

Heralding change Back in 1984, S Shanmugam, a resident of Vyasarpadi began Aarvam Bro Siga Animation Centre. He found the state of education in the community to be poor. The high school dropout rates in the neighbourhood egged him further. The reading circle was born as a result of need, rather than a want.

"Thanks to the library, I can teach my children general knowledge and politics," says 28-year-old homemaker Sreeja Udayakumar. According to her, Aarvam's community library has made reading and learning affordable. While she reads self-help and fiction, others in the community are drawn towards thrillers and mystery novels.

"I used to think school books were my whole life," says 15-year-old M Deepan. Listing *Maaya Manthra Kadhaikal* as his favourite book, Deepan talks of how this view has changed. He expresses his deep love for the Tamil language. "No matter how many languages there are, our mother tongue comes first, right?" he says. Deepan says his school library has books related to the syllabus, but fiction is hard to find.

"Most parents in the neighbourhood have not received any formal education. However, what we are noticing is that several first-generation graduates – their children – are turning up at the circle. The goal is to bring the culture of reading to a community that has been consistently neglected for years," Shanmugam says.

Kopi, congee, and comfort

Zhoyu's Singapore Breakfast Club is a tribute to the flavours of its hawker culture

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For those who have travelled to Singapore, it is the chaotic hawker centres scattered across the island that often leave the strongest impression. Brimming with the aromas of nasi lemak, laksa, satay, noodles, fried rice, roti prata, and cups of kopi and teh, these bustling food stalls are among Singapore's most iconic cultural symbols.

"But today, the food landscape is gradually evolving, and the younger generation is increasingly drawn to Korean cuisine," says Chef Chindi Varadarajulu, who owns Pumpkin Tales and Zhoyu. "As someone who grew up in Singapore, I truly miss that cherished sense of nostalgia." To recreate those fond memories and celebrate Singapore's beloved breakfast culture, the chef has launched the Singapore Breakfast Club, a weekend breakfast menu at Zhoyu, featuring iconic Singaporean morning staples.

We were handed an à la carte menu put together by the chef and her team when we arrived. Of the 12 dishes on offer, we decided to begin with Jook, or congee. Jook is the ultimate comfort food – a silky rice porridge slow-cooked until creamy and velvety. Alongside it, we ordered the Yam Cake. A canteen staple, yam cake is a savoury steamed rice

cake studded with taro, the starchy root vegetable. The dish was topped with crisp fried shallots and fresh spring onions, and served with a side of spicy sambal.

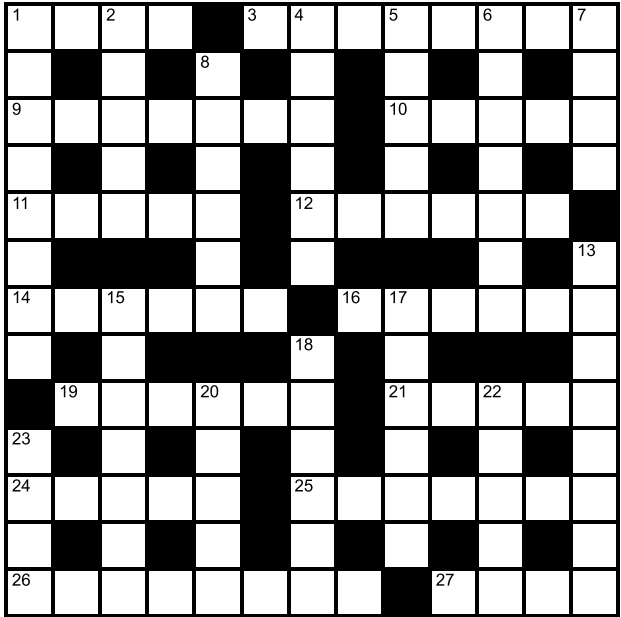
When the chef recommended the carrot cake, we expected a sweet slice. What landed on our table was nothing like the dessert we had imagined and was savory instead. "In Singapore, when we say 'carrot', we actually mean white radish," explains Chindi.

Next, we sampled Mee Siam. The dish was a comforting bowl of thin rice vermicelli bathed in a tangy, spicy tamarind-based gravy, topped with boiled egg, fried tofu, bean sprouts and fresh herbs. We rounded off our breakfast with a cup of kopi, Singapore's traditional coffee served with sweetened condensed milk. Still tempted to sample one more classic, we ordered a serving of Tau Huay, Singapore's silky tofu pudding. Made from freshly set soy milk and served with a light rock sugar syrup, the dessert was delicately sweet, incredibly smooth and almost custard-like in texture, providing a simple yet comforting finale to a hearty breakfast.

Singapore Breakfast Club at Zhoyu is on from July 26 at Alwarpet, and August 1 at their ECR branch. Available only on Saturday and Sunday from 8am to noon. A meal for two costs around ₹1,500. For reservations, call 48503090.



METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #63 (Set by Doppelganger)



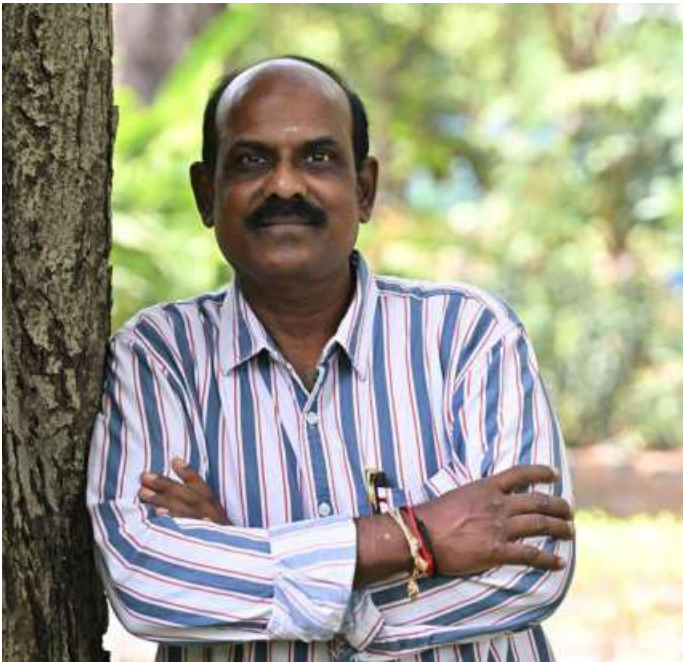
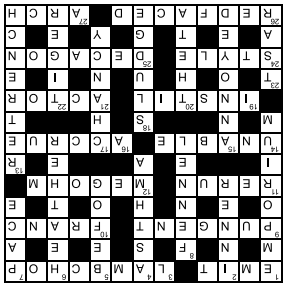
- Across**
- 1 Send out (4)
 - 3 Cut of meat (4,4)
 - 9 Caustic (7)
 - 10 French currency (5)
 - 11 Broadcast again (5)
 - 12 Unit of resistance (6)
 - 14 Powerless (6)
 - 16 Add up (6)
 - 19 Implant (6)
 - 21 Participant (5)
 - 24 Manner (5)
 - 25 Ten-sided figure (7)
 - 26 Embarrassed (3-5)
 - 27 Principal (4)
- Down**
- 1 Boutique (8)
 - 2 Privileged (5)
 - 4 Disease of the lungs (6)
 - 5 Muddle (5)
 - 6 Eurasian shrub (7)
 - 7 Walking speed (4)
 - 8 Herb (6)
 - 13 Cut down (8)

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- 15 Irritated (7)
- 17 Hazardous (6)
- 18 Sediment (6)
- 20 Eighth Greek alphabet (5)
- 22 Big cat (5)
- 23 Russian emperor (4)

Solution No. 63



A dream is but a seed

What does it take for a gardener who studied under a streetlight to retire as a manager at British Council?

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In the last day of a 40-year career that has undergone the unmissable seasaw of life, S Ganapathy, who began as a gardener at the British Council (BC), chose to reminisce the long swathes of time at the organisation. When the premises permanently closed in March earlier this year, he walked through the grass lawn that he once tended to.

In a crisp pinstripe shirt, he recorded this journey of going back to where his life started in the form of a cinematic video. He sent it out to friends, family, and colleagues, and when he did, he ensured that it went out with the song 'Venpani Malare' from the film *Power Pandi*, in the background, romanticising the

years gone by. "I think I've lived a successful life. It is not often that a gardener and maintenance person who once cleaned toilets, retires as facilities manager, South India," he said.

Unlike those who are able to enter formal workspaces with the privilege of education and pedigree, stories like that of Ganapathy's prove that those from economically and socially weaker sections of society can thrive when there are egalitarian systems to climb up the ranks with proportionate compensation in place. "My family moved from Vandavasi to Chennai in 1966 when I was



Whenever life knocked me down, I would cry – but then immediately think about how to rise again

Looking back (Left) S Ganapathy, now a former employee of British Council Chennai; and (below) from his archive. SRINATH M



very young. My father was a construction worker and my mother worked as a domestic help in several houses. By the time I was in Class X, the natural assumption was that I would enter the labour force and end up working so as to bring in money to the household. We lived in a slum near Loyola College so I studied under the street light. It wasn't until I joined the BC upon the recommendation of NS Prabhu, a mentor at whose house my mother worked, that I was able to see perceivable changes in my life," he says.

Getting on

Back in 1986, when he cycled to BC for his first day at work for a wage of ₹55 a month, Ganapathy was not let in by the security guard. In the initial days, he did all kinds of odd jobs. Cutting grass, trimming trees, taking care of maintenance work, and filling in when they needed a security personnel. "My superiors and the regular readers at BC made me realise that educating oneself is essential to rise up the ranks," he says.

Over the next 15 years, until 2003, Ganapathy qualified himself. He now has a Bachelor's and Master's degree in Tamil, another Bachelor's degree in Library and Information Science, and a

third in Law. He also went to an English-learning institute to improve his communication skills. Through his career, Ganapathy says that investing prudently helped his family life and career. He took loans,

trying to secure permanent housing for his family, and tried paying off debts, taking up second jobs as a milk man and auto driver. Tenacity, he says, is the only trait that pushed him forth. "Whenever life knocked me down, I would cry – but then immediately think about how to rise again. I struggled for food and education and have not wanted others to experience the same. It is why I set up a tuition centre in Nungambakkam for six years, and have since then, tried to help as many people gain an education," he says. Today, Ganapathy has plans to enrol as an advocate at the Madras High Court because he would like to assist his second daughter who is studying the degree. "Next year, when she begins practising, I want to be available for her. I can serve as her driver, peon, assistant, and researcher. It's a good life," he says.

Does he still garden? "How can I not? Today, it is spiritual to me," he says.



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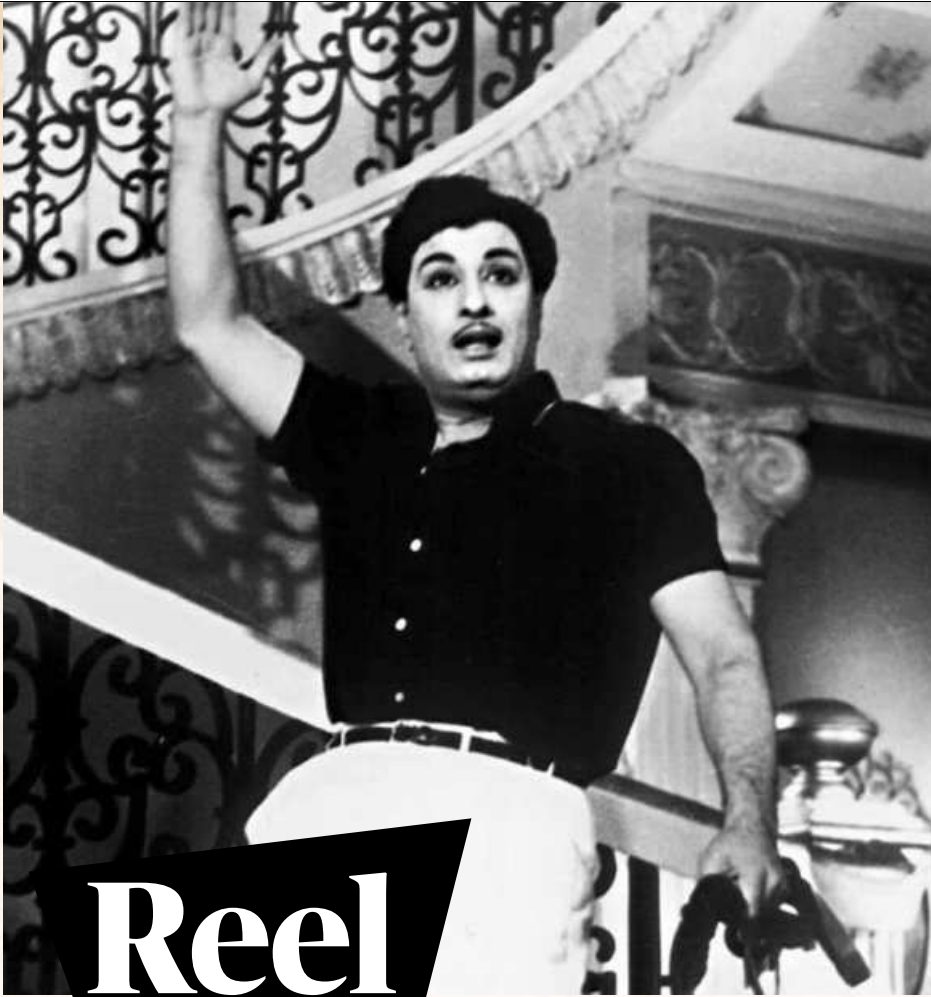
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When MGR became Chief Minister in 1977, Meenava Nanban was released. Nearly five decades later, Vijay's *Jana Nayagan* releases under strikingly similar circumstances

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Tamil Nadu has seen this only once before. And it is set to repeat. In a coincidence that connects C Joseph Vijay and MG Ramachandran – both popular actors before they became Chief Ministers of Tamil Nadu – a film release follows their big political moment. Actor Vijay's *Jana Nayagan* hits screens today, barely months after he took over as Chief Minister. Nearly five decades ago, something similar occurred: barely months after he took charge as Tamil Nadu Chief Minister, MG Ramachandran's *Meenava Nanban* hit screens.

What happened in 1977? Leading newspapers of the time captured the pre-release buzz of *Meenava Nanban*, with film posters only carrying the title 'Makkal Thilagam' and not 'Chief Minister'. T Rajappa Venkatachari – popularly known as 'MGR Swami' – remembers the excitement in 1977 when this MGR film hit the screen. In his thirties then, Rajappa vividly recalls watching the film's first-day-first-show at Tirunelveli's Central Theatre. "It was madness," he says, "There was great excitement among fans. Normally, during new



Reel repeat

Tamil film releases, policemen would wield the *lathi* in order to maintain law and order outside the cinema hall... but the scene was different for *Meenava Nanban* as MGR had become the Chief Minister. Policemen treated us [fans of MGR] with respect. They did wield *lathis*, but tapped the ground instead of targetting us... and requested orderliness." Directed by Sridhar, *Meenava Naban*, also starring Latha and VK Ramasamy, revolves around how Kumaran (played by MGR) fights for the cause of fishermen. Rajappa reminisces that for the first day shows and subsequent weekend screenings, watching the film along with hundreds of MGR

fans were hordes of fishermen from the neighbouring villages. This was a time when Tirunelveli district included areas in Thoothukudi and Tiruchendur, much before it was bifurcated into different districts. "Fishermen from the coastal villages of Thoothukudi would hire lorries to transport them to the main cinema hall in Tirunelveli, and watch the film. They were thrilled that MGR was championing the cause of fishermen through this picture," adds Rajappa, who is currently based in Alwarthirunagari, famous for being part of the 'Nava Tirupathi' temples. If *Meenava Nanban* marked MGR's immediate return to the big

screen after taking over as Chief Minister, his *Madhuraiyai Meeta Sundharapandiyan* arrived in January 1978. Widely regarded as his final screen appearance as an actor, this film had a troubled production, as it was stalled post the death of its filmmaker, BR Panthulu. It was MGR himself who took on directorial duties to complete this particular project.

MGR and films: the trust Despite taking over as Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, MGR had close links with the film industry. On April 14, 1978, barely 10 months into his tenure as Chief Minister, he kickstarted a new production starring himself. Reporting on that project, *The Hindu* quoted him as saying, "I am resuming acting not

A familiar script MGR and Vijay; (below) a still from *Meenava Nanban*. THE HINDU ARCHIVES



Normally, during new Tamil releases, policemen would wield the lathi to maintain law and order. For the release of *Meenava Nanban* at Tirunelveli's Central Theatre, they treated us [fans of MGR] with respect, because he had become the Chief Minister by that time

T RAJAPPA VENKATACHARI
MGR fan

merely to fulfil my obligations to those in the industry but to carry on through this medium my mission of propagating high and socially relevant ideals, especially those of my mentor, 'Anna'. I have a lot to tell the public about the problems of the farming community and my ideas of solving them," MGR stated, adding, "Acting will not hit work." Later, in a report carried in *The Hindu* on August 30, 1979, MGR is quoted as saying, "I will not leave the cine field. I cannot say whether I will act again. But I will produce and direct films." However, a lack of time and attention to public work meant that MGR could not fully fulfil his wishes.

What's happening in 2026 Cut to the present day, and Tamil cinema fans are awaiting the release of *Jana Nayagan*, starring Chief Minister Vijay. Set to hit screens on July 23, the release will finally end the months-long drama surrounding its fate. Directed by H Vinoth, the political action thriller reportedly has the protagonist playing a retired police officer drawn back to public life due to circumstances. It is said to explore themes of social justice and protecting the vulnerable, much like what MGR did in most of his films, including *Meenava Nanban*. *Jana Nayagan* was originally slated for a January 9, 2026 release ahead of Pongal. However, the film's release was marred by significant delays, legal interventions and piracy issues. It is expected to be the last time Vijay makes an on-screen appearance. "For the fans who gave up everything for me, I'm giving up cinema itself," he famously said during the audio release of *Jana Nayagan* held in Malaysia in December 2025. Now in his third month as Chief Minister even as *Jana Nayagan* hits screens, Vijay finds himself at a remarkably similar crossroads as MGR did – though, whether his journey follows MGR's remains to be seen.



Explorer at heart Singer Shakthisree Gopalan. SHIVARAJ S

My old friend

Singer Shakthisree Gopalan on her most personal work yet, a track that talks about her mental health

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It was during the lockdown in 2020 that Shakthisree Gopalan put pen to paper for a song. On a particularly uneventful day – the kind that makes you question where life is headed and revisit past incidents – the singer-songwriter penned this line, "Why should I pay a price to be myself when the world is going mad?" Those words would finally find a home in 'Old Friend', her latest track that may well be her most 'vulnerable' work yet. "It's about my inner demons. It holds everything – from my neurodivergence, my mental health, and above all, choosing myself," she writes in a note.

First featured at a Friday student concert during her days at Berklee NYC, 'Old Friend' is a deeply lived song. "It is," she admits, "Every time I have performed this song, some part of me healed." 'Old Friend' has been many years in the making, a factor that makes Shakthisree draw parallels to American singer-songwriter Don Henley's 'The Heart of the Matter'. "He famously said that it took him 40 years to write that song, and four minutes to sing it. I finally understood what he meant. I had a phase when I used to feel broken, without holding myself with grace and kindness. There was a turning point when I gave it a name – that it was an 'Old Friend'. It made it easy for me to navigate through life." Recorded and filmed live in Brooklyn, NYC, 'Old Friend', which dropped on music platforms recently, comes at a significant time – one during which independent music is having its moment. Closer home, tracks such as Kaber Vasuki's recent independent 'Frangipani' is also opening doors to conversations on mental health. Did she feel any hesitation in sharing her journey to the world? "When I first sang it, I felt naked and



bare," she recalls, "But the more I let out, I felt a part of me healed. While my film singing career gave me a chance to step into the shoes of many beautiful characters, independent music gives me the freedom to channelise my voice." Not many people are aware that Shakthisree is also an architect and has designed AR Rahman's music school (KM Music Conservatory) and re-designed a portion of Panchathan, the composer's recording suite. "This intersection of space and sound is the playground that I love puzzling in. Designing KM Music Conservatory was a dream project for me – because my thesis at architecture school was 'designing music schools'." Her other dream project has been SoundGarden, a multi-sensory, interactive installation that invites people to play with sound, light and space. Last showcased at Sabha BLR in Bengaluru in 2024, she is mulling on an online version currently. "I'm an explorer at heart. I've also been vibe coding with Claude and presenting the SoundGarden concept in hackathons. It's in the middle of everything I love – an exploration of space and sound – and I wish it goes places."

'Old Friend' streams on YouTube and other music platforms.

